UCLA Engineering
HENRY SAMUELI SCHOOL OF ENGINEERING AND APPLIED SCIENCE
Electrical and Computer Engineering Department

February 2, 2025

Re: Nomination of Eilam Morag for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award for a Teaching Assistant

To Selection Committee:

I am very enthusiastic to nominate Eilam Morag for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award for a Teaching Assistant.

Eilam Morag is one of our department's most accomplished TAs. He has been a TA for 8 quarters, teaching a variety of undergraduate courses: ECE101B: Engineering Electromagnetics, and ECE2: Physics for Electrical Engineers. He is highly thought of by faculty – who are eager to have him TA for their courses. Indeed, he served as a TA once for me in ECE2, so I know firsthand his skill in communicating difficult material to students in a way that they enjoy. The feedback from students from his courses is stellar – I know this because I saw the student letters provided for when he received our departmental teaching award: the 2022-2023 Samueli Excellence in Teaching Award. Because of his extensive experience, the department selected him to be the TA Coordinator in Fall 2025, who served as the TA for ECE M495 – the TA training class that all departmental TAs must take. Although this class has a faculty instructor as well, I know that in practice much of the work and actual instruction is done by the TA coordinator. As I read his self-statement, and read some of the feedback from students, it is clear to me that he has spent considerable time refining his pedagogical approaches. He is very thoughtful and deliberate in his teaching style, making sure to use the whiteboard, coming up with creative examples, and bringing in video demos or hands-on examples for the students to explore. He is always highly available to students beyond discussion sections and office hours, and on many occasions has me one-on-one with students who are struggling. He incorporates a number of active learning approaches, and gets the students engaged and involved in discussion sections.

Eilam is a tremendous asset to our department, and I think he is well suited for this Award. I hope you strongly consider his nomination – he has our department's full support.

Sincerely,

Benjamin Williams

Benjamin S. Williams
Professor and Chairman, Department of Electrical and Computer Engineering
University of California Los Angeles
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I have served as a TA in UCLA's Electrical and Computer Engineering Department (ECE) for eight quarters, covering lecture courses on electromagnetic waves (ECE 101B) and semiconductor physics (ECE 2/2H). I consistently receive positive feedback from students [Artifact 1: red] and I received the 2022-2023 Samueli Excellence in Teaching Award. I have also recently served one quarter as the Teaching Assistant Consultant for ECE M495. **I believe I fit the award criteria because my teaching style emphasizes active, student-centered discussions, because I engage and inspire my students, and because I build supportive classroom environments that encourage participation**.

I believe the most effective use of my students' time is a combination of an active, weekly review, followed by example problems that bridge the gap between lecture and homework. This belief is supported by student feedback [Artifact 1: blue]. The review synthesizes the week's separate concepts, breaks down complex ideas into manageable chunks, and clarifies common points of confusion [Artifact 2]. In class, I maintain several simple practices that make an impact. I almost exclusively use the board, which slows me down to a digestible pace. I write and speak clearly and turn often to look at the students to gauge their understanding. I use visual aids extensively and I encourage my students to do the same. For example, when I teach them about "polarization states," I tell them to orient the wave so it travels toward them and I sketch a stick figure looking into a laser; a bad idea in real life, to be sure, but quite a memorable image. Finally, to reach students who have a hard time focusing in class, I regularly share written material on Bruinlearn. In addition to my discussion notes, which are designed to be read, I also create and post supplemental notes, simulation codes, and detailed figures and animations [Artifact 3].

Electrical engineering, like all technical subjects, can be tedious and difficult to learn. It is immensely gratifying, however, when you finally grasp a concept, and even more so when you finally get to build something. To inspire my students, I try to inject a bit of this excitement into my discussions [Artifact 1: yellow]. I primarily do this by tying the abstract concepts to real-world applications and my own research experience. I have received the best feedback, however, when I bring in pieces of the lab: real components that the students are studying in class. I have brought in waveguides, antennas, and semiconductor samples [Artifact 4]. I recently built and wheeled in an optical experiment. One of the sessions that my ECE 101B students consistently praise the most is the discussion of waveguides [Artifact 1: yellow]. In class, the students learn about the simplest type of waveguide, called a "rectangular waveguide." These are essentially metallic pipes with rectangular cross-sections, and their electromagnetic properties depend on their dimensions. Each quarter, I bring in a few and pass them around the class. They squint and peer through them and take pictures with their phones. I ask for a volunteer to measure a specific waveguide's dimensions with a ruler,

and we then calculate its properties as a class. To illustrate how the wave changes with time in the waveguide—a concept that students routinely struggle with—I play and explain an animation that I generated. I share the code for generating these animations with the students, so they can try them out by themselves after class.

Finally, I strive to make my discussions and office hours supportive environments, where students always feel respected and understand that I care about their success [Artifact 1: green]. I try to build genuine relationships with my students, learning their names and asking about their academic plans. I am generous with my time, often extending office hours by 30-60 minutes to get to everyone, and I continue answering questions on Campuswire or Piazza, by email, and occasionally on Bruinlearn [Artifact 5]. I make a point of relating my own struggles and admitting my mistakes to give my students implicit permission to struggle and make their own mistakes. In discussions and office hours, I admit when I do not know the answer to something and I make sure to follow up with an explanation as soon as I can, which builds trust with the students [Artifact 1: green].

TAing has been one of the most rewarding parts of my PhD experience. Thank you for considering me for this award.

I have two goals as a teacher: to help my students succeed in the course, and to share my enthusiasm for electrical engineering and inspire them to continue studying it. I can best achieve these goals by practicing certain values: being knowledgeable and prepared, treating my students with kindness and respect, and engaging my students through active learning.

I value being knowledgeable and prepared so I can facilitate discussions that are useful to my students. The quality of my own instruction depends strongly on the flow of my explanations. This flow rarely comes naturally to me: I think for hours about how I build my arguments so that the discussion follows a clean and logical path. Students typically come to discussions for clarity: in a specific idea, in the connection between ideas, or in the application of theory to a problem. If I give a convoluted, ill-planned explanation, then I will lose their focus and waste their time. To adequately prepare, I have to first know all the material they covered that week. I have to know what they covered in lecture and what notation they are using. I have to know when things are due and when exams are. That means, in the first quarter teaching a class, I must attend all the lectures, read all the readings, and do all the homework. In going through all the students' material with my base of knowledge, I can identify topics that will be useful to all my students: potential pitfalls, common threads between subjects, and jumps in abstraction.

I value treating students with kindness, patience, and respect, so that they trust me enough to ask questions and participate. I try to learn students' names so I can build a genuine connection with them. I strongly encourage questions and make it clear to my students that no (relevant) question is too small. On the flip side, I have also learned when to answer a small tangential question and when to defer it to office hours, to respect other students' time. Furthermore, as a student, I was concerned about making mistakes and appearing unintelligent. As a teacher, I try to create an environment where students feel comfortable making mistakes. I accomplish that by being honest when I do make mistakes. During a recent midterm review that I led, for example, I had a recursive problem that could be simplified by identifying a pattern and applying it a certain amount of times. I got mixed up on the board and had to pause, admit my error, and double back to an earlier point. It was an embarrassing experience, but also a useful one for the students: if I can make a mistake and recover, then surely they are allowed to, too.

I value active strategies that engage my students. As a PhD candidate, the concepts I understand and remember best are the ones I have hands-on experience with: those I have had to teach or use in the lab. As a TA for a lecture course, I do not have access to lab resources, but I have learned a few valuable techniques over the years. Generally, I like to create questions in the zone of proximal development and solve them as a class. I vary my degree of guidance based on where the class is. For example, in a previous offering of ECE 101B, the class had learned in lecture how to calculate the fraction of

electromagnetic power reflected from an object with a coating, like the kind sometimes found on windshields. The question I posed was, “consider that instead of one layer of coating, there are two: how much power is reflected?” The class struggled to extend the model to two coating layers, so I walked through it with them, pausing for questions along the way. Then, I extended the question to include three, and then four, and then n layers. By starting at a known point and continuously pushing the question a little beyond, I was able to keep the students engaged and make genuine progress in their learning.

Finally, I value growing as a teacher. I do this through both unstructured and structured means. I have spent the last four years in regular discussions with my TA peers about how to improve: how to plan discussions, how to engage students, how to grade fairly and effectively. I have also mentored friends of mine who are just starting out as TAs. I learn from this exchange, too, because I share my notes and observe how my friends change them to fit their style. I have recently made my first foray into structured improvement by serving as the TAC for ECE M495. Leading that class forced me to reflect upon my own teaching style, and to consider what changes I could make to improve. For example, I learned how to improve my exam rubrics. I have always struggled with these, because I could never quite predict how students will make mistakes, or I assumed students would struggle with one aspect of a question, yet they would mostly struggle with another. By attending the TAC academy and reviewing the learning modules, I learned about single-point rubrics. This is a promising approach for me, because I can easily define an A, yet it gives me the freedom to leaf through some exams and see where students got stuck before deciding on the requirements for the other grades.

In my teaching, I strive to be prepared and knowledgeable, so I can deliver concise reviews and facilitate effective discussions. I aim to treat my students with kindness and respect, so as to develop a supportive environment where they feel safe engaging and making mistakes. I endeavor to make my lessons active and engaging, so that the students develop a deeper and longer-lasting understanding of the material. Finally, I am committed to continually improving as a teacher, so I can better help my students succeed and inspire in them a curiosity and excitement for electrical engineering.

Red: general praise	Green: supportive	Blue: helpful, clear	Yellow: engaging, inspiring

- Eilam is an absolutely phenomenal TA. He showed a genuine concern for student learning and was highly capable to explain difficult topics. Eilam is probably the best TA I have had at UCLA.
- Eilam is such an engaging and kind TA. He made me feel comfortable in asking my questions and had a strong grasp on all of the concepts, making it easy for us to understand what he was explaining/ clarifying.
- Eilam did a seriously incredible job as TA. Definitely one of the best TA's I've had at UCLA, no question. His discussions helped on the homework, and were insightful and easy to follow, while also being interesting. Great Job Eilam! He is a rockstar.
- Very knowledgeable in the subject and passionate. He adds lots of outside perspectives and tricks that he has learned over his time that were maybe not mentioned or taught in lecture. Great TA and very approachable.

ECE 101B, 22S Electromagnetic Waves

- Eilam is by far the best TA I have ever had at this school. He understands the subject extremely well and can concisely answer students' questions. He gives relevant summaries of lecture and goes over relevant example problems. He also brings in actual antennas and waveguides etc for us to look at and see what we are actually learning about, making discussion interesting. He always puts in an effort to make students understand the material and find it interesting and intuitive, a skill TAs should aspire to have. Eilam deserves the best, as he is definitely one of the best TAs at this school.
- The TA was amazing, very helpful and engaging discussions. Good communication.
- Eilam is such a great TA!!! He is so helpful and his discussion sections are like mini lectures. I loved how he brought cool trinkets to discussion like waveguides and antennas for us to observe -- very thoughtful. Any student would be lucky to have him as a TA. 10/10
- Eilam went above and beyond as a TA! His discussions were extremely worthwhile and reviewed lecture material in a way that was really helpful for completing the homework and preparing for exams. He'd make it fun too and brought in waveguides and antennas to show us, just because. He always took as long as necessary to make sure any questions were properly answered and that the answer was understood.

ECE 101B, 23W Electromagnetic Waves

- Eilam is one of the best if not the best TA I've had. He not only goes in-depth in the discussions so we don't feel so lost after seeing so much content in the lecture, but also comes to lectures, so whenever I have a question chances are he's probably there to answer it. Fantastic.
- Excellent teaching assistant; was extremely committed to answering student questions after lectures, during discussions, and online through Piazza. I always felt that I got an expanded perspective of the course content after each discussion session and made it a point to attend discussion each week.
- I genuinely cannot praise Eilam enough here. He was incredibly knowledgeable with respect to the course material, and always went above and beyond to help the students, answering emails in depth and staying past his office hours to answer questions. His explanations of the material were sublime, and I can say that one lecture he gave during the discussion section regarding PN junctions may be one of the most perfectly flowing and organized presentations I've ever seen. The only criticism I'd have is that sometimes during our discussion sections he'd just spend around half the time answering people's homework questions when I would rather have had him lecture like he'd planned to, but also I feel like that was more so due to people taking advantage of his kindness.
- The TA had great explanations, very thorough and insightful. He filled in some gaps that were present from lectures. He always took the time to answer questions. He also went out of his way to remember some of our names. This was really interesting because I've never had a TA that asked for the names of their students. The fact that he cared enough to actual see us beyond just students was admirable. He is very knowledgable about the course content, and if anything, he'd over-explain concepts.

ECE 2, 23F Physics for Elec. Engr.

- Eilam was amazing! He knew the material extremely well and was very good at explaining the concepts. He was approachable and really made the class an great learning experience.
- The TA was fantastic and was very knowledgeable. He cares about whether students understand the content and is able to help students understand class content through discussion sections.
- Eilam is an excellent TA. He is very knowledgeable about course material and cares deeply about students' understanding. He explains things very clearly and answers questions very thoroughly. Overall, his discussions and office hours sections were very valuable and helpful.

ECE 2H, 24W Hon. Phys. for Elec. Engr.

Red: general praise	Green: supportive	Blue: helpful, clear	Yellow: engaging, inspiring

- Eilam is an excellent teaching assistant who has a really good grasp on how to explain concepts in an intuitive manner, and makes things easy to understand for students. He is very approachable and I very much enjoyed his style of teaching, as it felt very easy to stop at any point and ask him questions.
- Eilam is among the best TAs that I have had at UCLA in electrical engineering. You could tell that he took his time when he spoke and answered our questions in discussion to make sure he was communicating in a clear as way as possible. The examples and notes he posted and what we went over in discussion was also extremely clear and helpful. thank you eilam
- Eilam's discussions are always very helpful, as he gives an overview of the week's material that helps us see the big picture in a course that otherwise quickly becomes very formula-heavy. He posts notes and provides the right amount of assistance with homework problems - guiding us in the correct direction without revealing the solution. He also provided multiple demos to help explain topics such as modes and antennas. His discussions are fast-paced at times.
- Elian is an awesome TA. He knows his stuff, always comes in with review material and examples prepared, writes very neatly on the board, takes all our questions, and is a really nice guy overall. Makes attending every single discussion session worth it, especially since the lecture content can be challenging to digest. Highly recommend him overall.

ECE 101B, 24S
Electromagnetic Waves

- Eilam is one of the best TAs I have ever had. I was really confused and overwhelmed with this course and he always went above and beyond to make sure every question I had was answered and any concept I had struggled with made manageable. Truly an exceptional individual and I am eternally grateful for all of the help with this course. Also extremely knowledgable and you can tell so immediately :)
- GREATEST TA EVER. If he was a professor I would take every class with him. Very smart and gives excellent intuitive explanations of difficult material
- This TA was always smiling when he teached and it really helped the students to stay engaged. He would also crack jokes here and there to prevent everyone from "drifting" away.
- T.A. Morag is amazing at explaining course material, as well as answering questions. He is very clear and knowledgeable about the course. His discussion sections are immensely helpful, as was his in-class review section. I have no criticisms; I hope he continues being a T.A. or a lecturer.
- Eliam Morag was a great TA. His strengths included: Presenting a review of the lectures we had gone over that same week which were extremely valuable. The discussions explained the material in a manner that was easier to understand. Morga made sure that students understood and were following along and created an environment in the discussions that made us comfortable to speak freely and ask questions when we didn't understand something. Morag made the discussions interactive and polled all the students for answers then would go over the answer and made sure to be thorough in his explanation if someone had a misunderstanding. He would also try different approaches to explaining difficult to understand concepts. Morag had a great understanding of the subject and I had a lot of confidence in the information he was teaching us. There are no weaknesses I could find in the TA.

ECE 2, 24F
Physics for Elec. Engr.

- Best TA that I have had by far. Noticeably high enthusiasm in supplementing students' curiosity as well as guiding their understanding and perspective of the subject. Not to mention, generally a VERY kind, approachable, polite individual. Makes a difference in the educational environment in that he is very astute and wants to share that. I highly admire Eilam for not only his profound understanding of EE but also his personage; he cares a lot about his immediate interactions, not just about his performance during a discussion (which is top notch just to note). It's inspiring and I walk out of discussion every week with a strong sense of validation that I am in the right place--one where I can be inspired about my field and develop new aspirations for personal growth.
- Eilam is no-doubt one of the greatest TAs in the department, and I looked forward to attending his discussion every week and found them very valuable. I liked how he would recap the material taught in lecture and then help guide us on the homework questions. One of my favorite parts was how he would bring in real-life waveguides and antennas and things that showed us how the concepts we were learning in lecture actually looked like in the real world and it made things click.
- Eilam is actually the most goated TA I've had. He is personable and approachable with questions, and his discussion materials are informative, clear, and well-prepared. It is clear he is very knowledgable about this topic and cares about student learning. I greatly appreciate the effort he puts in to this class.
- Genuinely an absolute pleasure to work with: I could not tell you a single real weakness of his! Amazing presentation, amazing personality, and certainly very knowledgeable!

ECE 101B, 25S
Electromagnetic Waves

Disc. 2

Oct. 13, 2023

This week's big picture:

State the big picture to synthesize material, give them a goal.

- We want to know how e⁻s travel thru semiconductors & solids generally → get electric transport model
- electrons small → quantum effects dominate (uncert. principle)

$$\Delta x \Delta p \geq \hbar/2$$

Δx and/or Δp can be large compared to the problem dimensions

- In quantum, everything probabilistic. All info about system contained in a function called the wavefunction, Ψ.
- Schrödinger eqn describes how Ψ may vary w/ space + time

$$\left[\frac{\hat{p}^2}{2m} + V(x)\right]\Psi(x,t) = i\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial t}\Psi(x,t)$$

Break down equation into simpler parts, connect to familiar equation

kinetic energy | potential energy | total energy

$$\hat{p} = -j\hbar\nabla \rightarrow -j\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial x} \text{ in 1D}$$

classical analog: $\frac{p^2}{2m} + V(x) = E$

- Potential energy describes the forces acting upon the system
- We narrow the solution space to separable functions

$$\Psi(x,t) = \psi(x)\phi(t)$$

Language like "narrow" motivates this step, gives students understanding

This gives us the time-indep. Schrö. eqn (TISE)

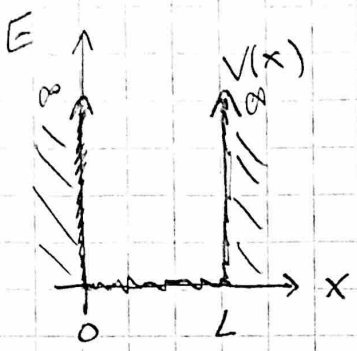
$$\left[\frac{\hat{p}^2}{2m} + V(x)\right]\psi(x) = E\psi(x)$$

- We have a few canonical problems

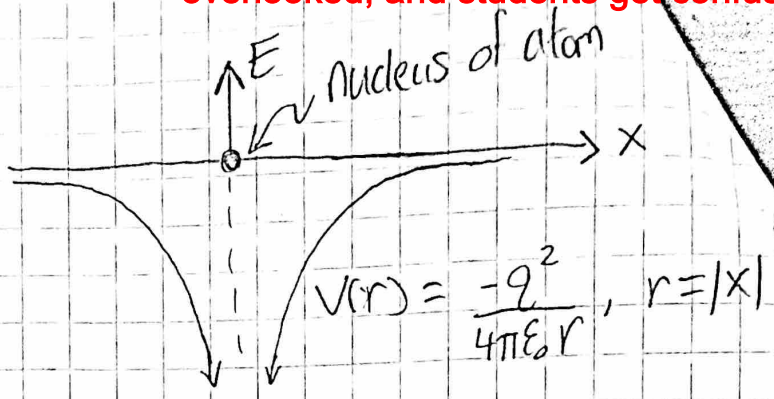
Explain what we're going to do next

Sketch figures of canonical problems: they stick in the head better than equations alone

All axes labelled! This is often overlooked, and students get confused



Inf. pot. well
(AKA particle-in-a-box)



Hydrogen atom

We plug the above V(x) values to TISE & solve for the allowed wavefunctions & their associated energies

↓ $\psi_n(x)$ ↓ E_n

Tie the jargon to the variables

- Probability density: $\psi_n^* \psi_n = |\psi_n|^2$

Some useful equations for homework

- Expect. value: $\langle \hat{p}_x \rangle = \iiint_{-\infty}^{\infty} \psi_n^*(x,y,z)\, \hat{p}_x\, \psi_n(x,y,z)\, dx\, dy\, dz$

  $\hat{p}_x \rightarrow -i\hbar \frac{\partial}{\partial x}$

- Time dependence assoc. w/ State ψ_n: $\phi_n(t) = e^{-i\omega_n t}$, $\omega_n = E_n/\hbar$

  $\Psi_n(x,t) = \psi_n(x)\phi_n(t)$

- In proximity, wavefns of atoms split & form hybrid states. Eventually, w/ enough atoms, get bands of energies

- Many bands, depending on element, but we only care about 2:
  - Valence band: topmost (highest energy) fully filled band
  - Conduction band: the band above that

Example problem. There was another problem in reserve in case there was extra time, but I removed it from the artifact to save space.

D2

Ch 2.3

A free e^- is traveling in the x-direction w/ a kinetic energy of 0.025 eV

a.) Write the eqn of the wavefn for this particle

$$\psi(x,t) = e^{i(kx-\omega t)}$$

b.) Find wavenumber, wavelength, & angular freq of this wave

$KE = \frac{p^2}{2m} = 0.025\ eV$, $p = \hbar k$

$p = \sqrt{2m(0.025\ eV)} = \sqrt{2(9.11E{-}31\ kg)(0.025\ eV)(1.602E{-}19\ J/eV)}$

$= 8.54E{-}26\ \left(\frac{kg\text{-}m}{s}\right) = \left(J\cdot\frac{s}{m}\right)$

Explicitly show which numbers I plug in, to avoid guesswork.

$k = \frac{8.54E{-}26\ J\text{-}s/m}{6.63E{-}34\ J\text{-}s/2\pi} = 8.09E8\ m^{-1}$

$\lambda = \frac{2\pi}{k} = 7.76\ nm$

$\omega = E/\hbar = \frac{0.025\ eV}{6.58E{-}16\ eV\text{-}s} = 3.80E13\ rad/s$

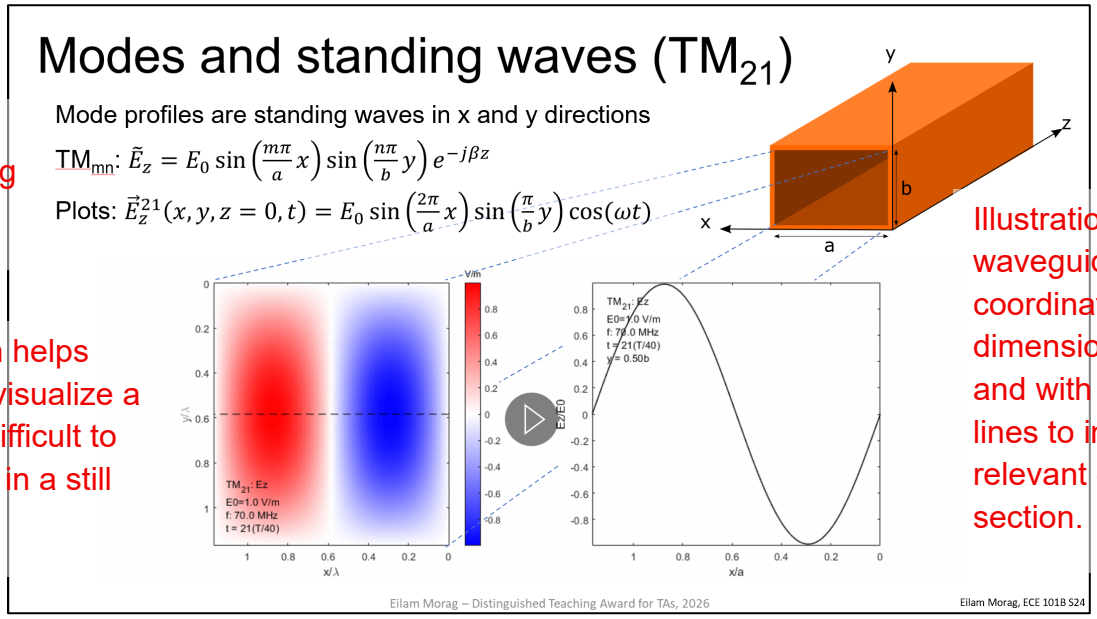
ARTIFACT 4: Supplemental material and figures, animations

I have created many supplemental figures and animations over the years to help students understand complicated or time-dependent phenomena. This is a selection of the best ones.

Exhibit 1: Rectangular waveguide supplement

The purpose of this slide is to show an animation (click here) which shows the time-dependent behavior of the electric field in the cross-section of the waveguide.

Clearly state what I'm plotting here.

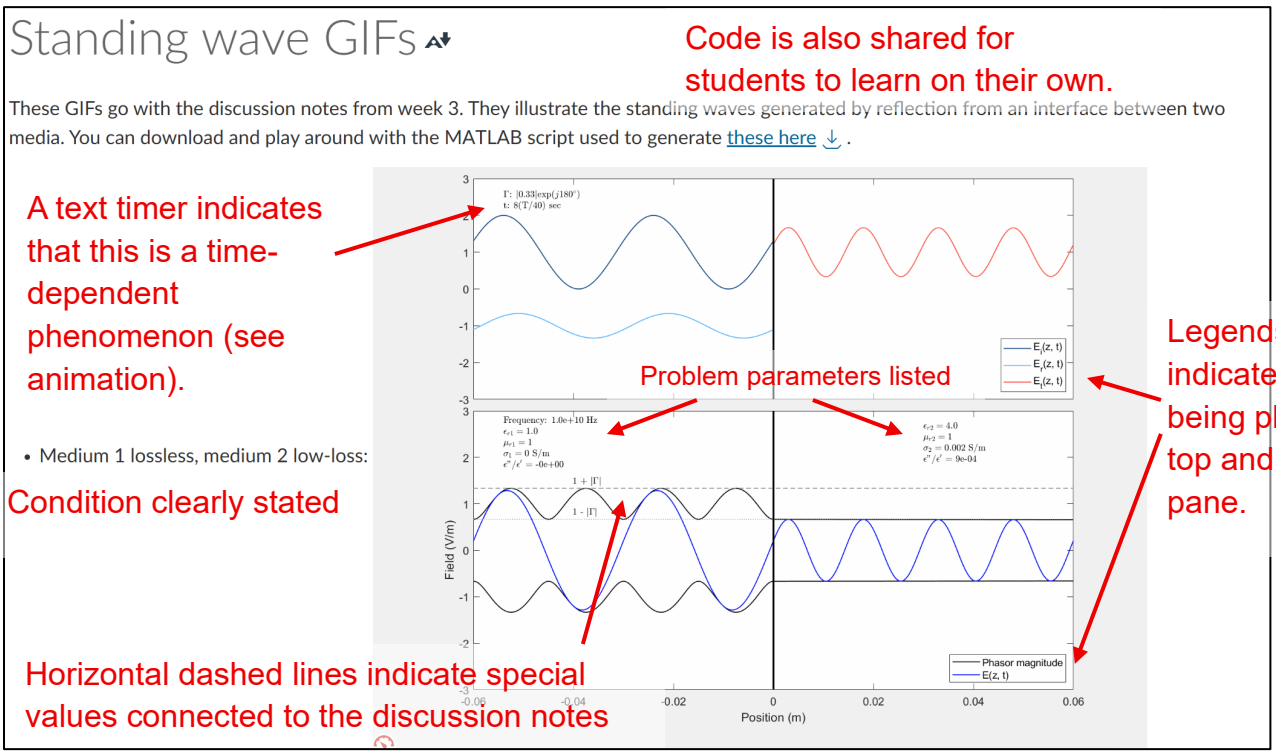


Animation helps students visualize a concept difficult to represent in a still image.

Illustration of the waveguide, with coordinates and dimensions listed, and with dashed lines to indicate the relevant cross-section.

Exhibit 2: Reflections and standing waves supplement

This is a screenshot from Bruinlearn. The image in the screenshot is a still frame from one of five animations (click here **to see this one**). The text in the screenshot is small, but it is visible in the animation. The animation shows how a wave incident from the left partially reflects off the interface between two materials (black vertical line). The bottom pane shows how a standing wave is partially formed. I also shared the code I used to generate these scripts.



Code is also shared for students to learn on their own.

A text timer indicates that this is a time-dependent phenomenon (see animation).

Problem parameters listed

Legends clearly indicate what is being plotted in top and bottom pane.

Condition clearly stated

Horizontal dashed lines indicate special values connected to the discussion notes

Exhibit 3: Transmission line model for multi-layer reflections

This figure was posted as is. It contains everything needed to apply the "transmission line model" to solve problems involving waves reflecting off stacks of multiple layers, including an example.

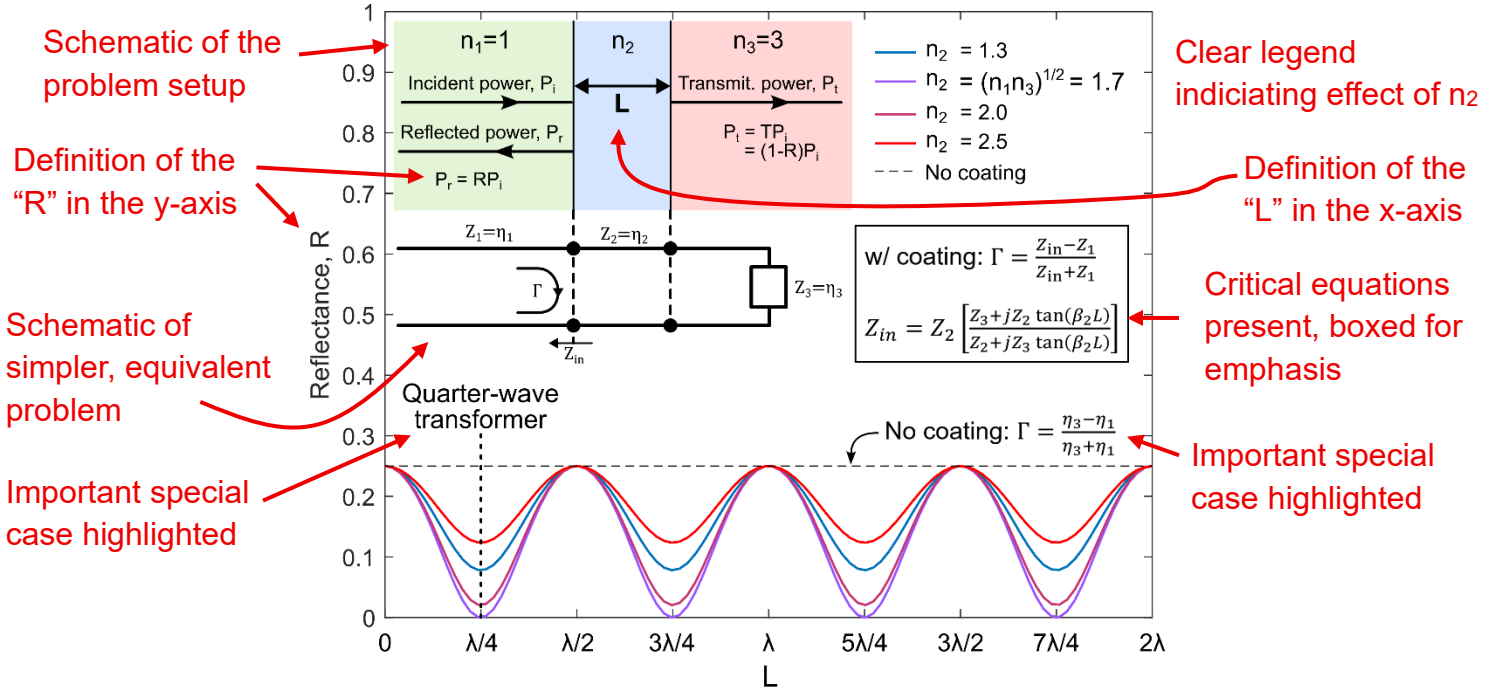
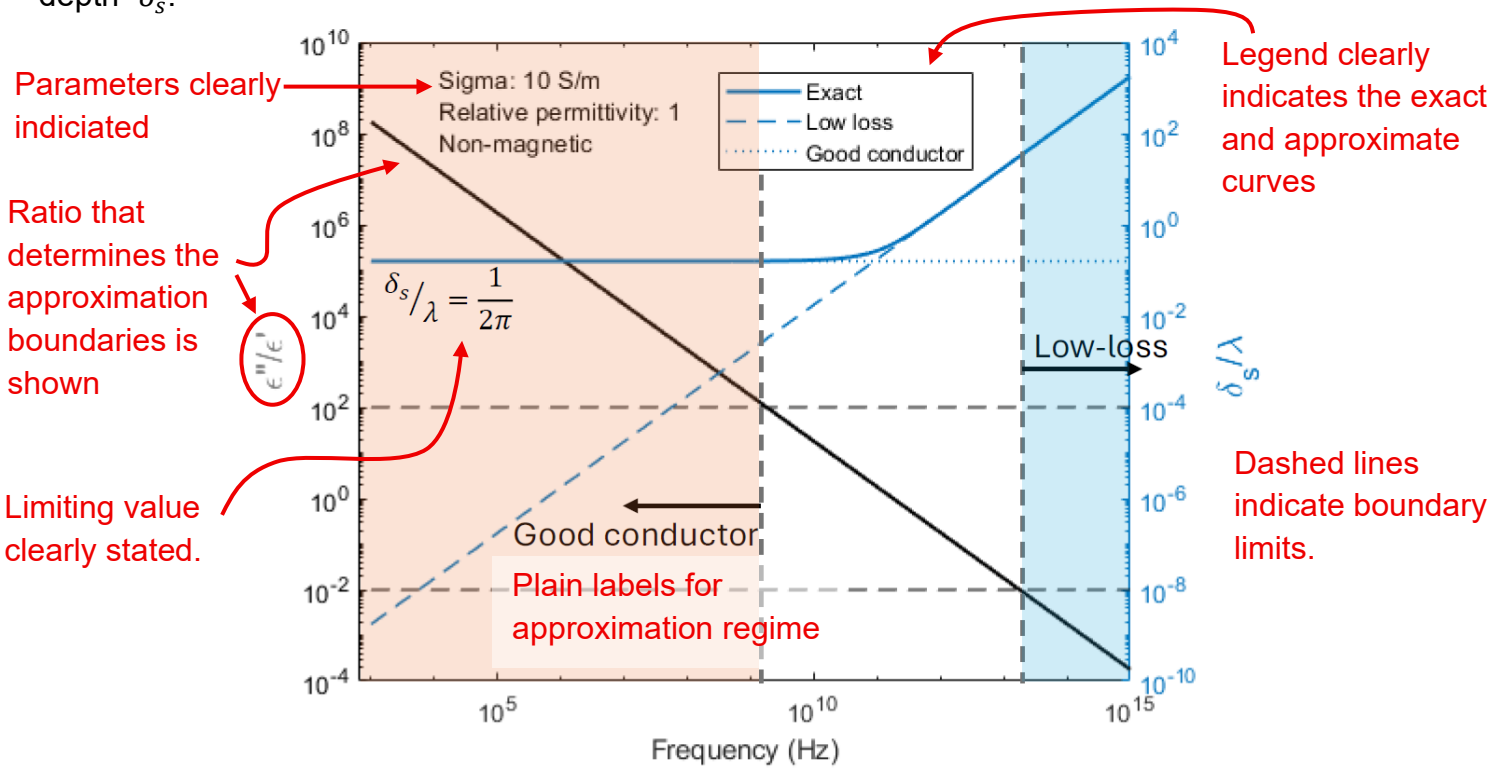


Exhibit 4: Accuracy of "skin depth" approximations

This figure shows how accurate the "good conductor" and "low-loss" approximations are for the "skin depth" δ_s.

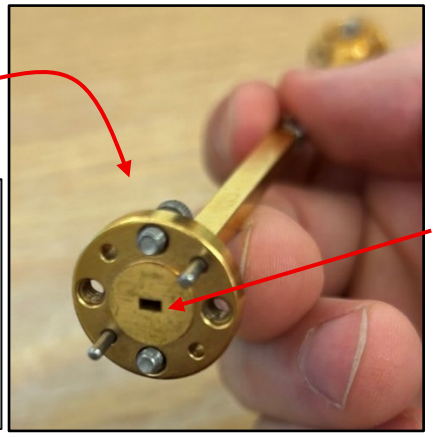


ARTIFACT 4: Real-world components to inspire

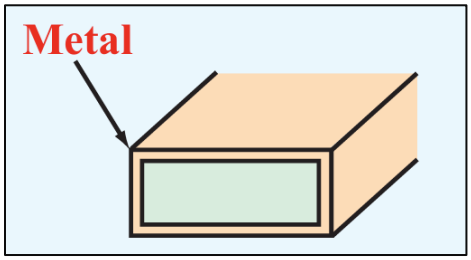
Exhibit 1: Real rectangular waveguides

I have brought in real rectangular waveguides to inspire my students. These were used in research experiments by a former professor in our department. These are the exact same waveguides as the ones the students study.

One of several real waveguides I brought in.



Book illustration of rect. waveguide

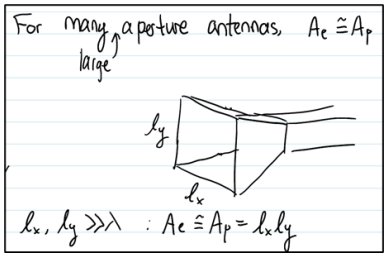


Students measure dimensions of this aperture, and we use their values for a practice problem.

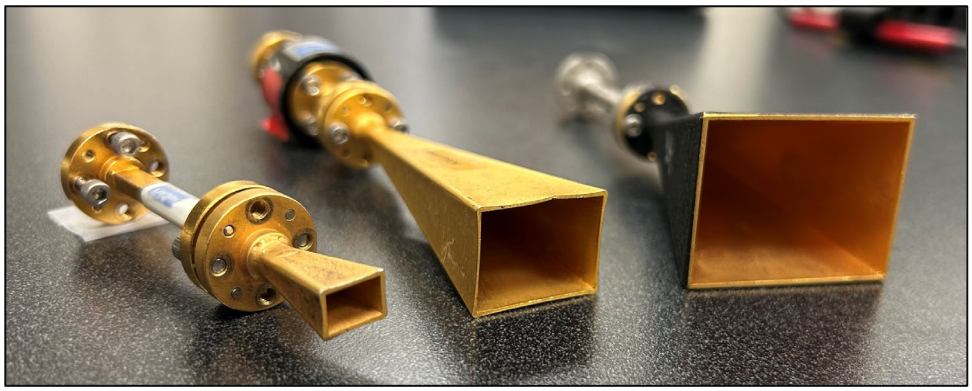
Exhibit 2: Real antennas

I have also brought in real horn and dipole antennas, which are studied in the class. Students often struggle to understand the dipole illustration in the book, so I made a crude “half-wave” dipole designed for WiFi frequencies to bring in. It’s dinky, but it picked up some signals from my phone!

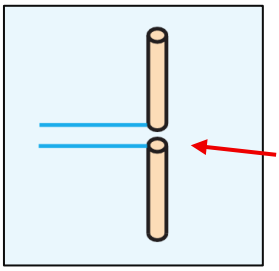
Real horn antennas of varying aperture



My illustration of a horn antenna from discussion notes. Aperture area is noted.

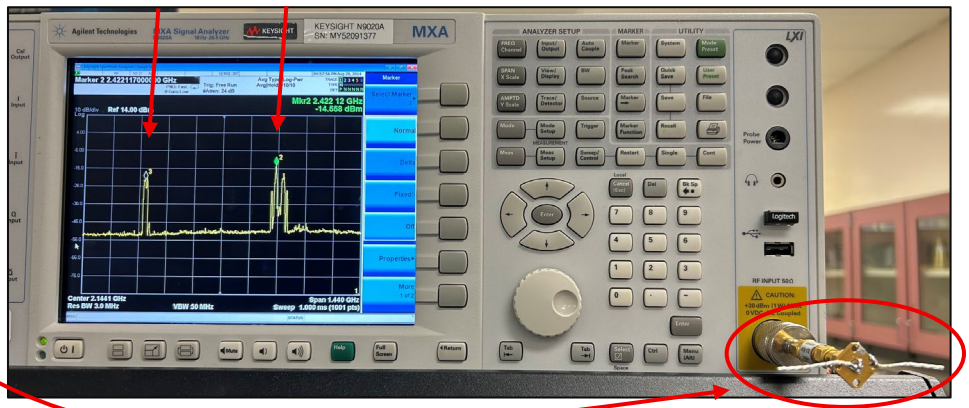


Connected to rectangular waveguides, to **show students how concepts come together in real life**



Book illustration of dipole antenna is unclear to students

Tested the antenna and it picked up signals from my phone.





I made a (crude) **dipole antenna** to show them how simple it is.

ARTIFACT 4: Real-world components to inspire

One quarter, **I borrowed antennas developed by my former instructor's lab.** Unfortunately, I have no photos of these!



Eilam Morag <eilam@g.ucla.edu> Sat, Mar 4, 2023, 11:59 AM

to Yahya

Hi Professor Rahmat-Samii,

It's been a while since I took your classes -- I hope you've been well. I'm TAing for ECE 101B this quarter and my students have just started learning about antennas. I'd like to bring in some antennas to inspire them -- would you mind loaning out a few antennas to me?

Thanks,
Eilam



Yahya Rahmat-Samii <rahmat@ee.ucla.edu> Mar 4, 2023, 12:10 PM

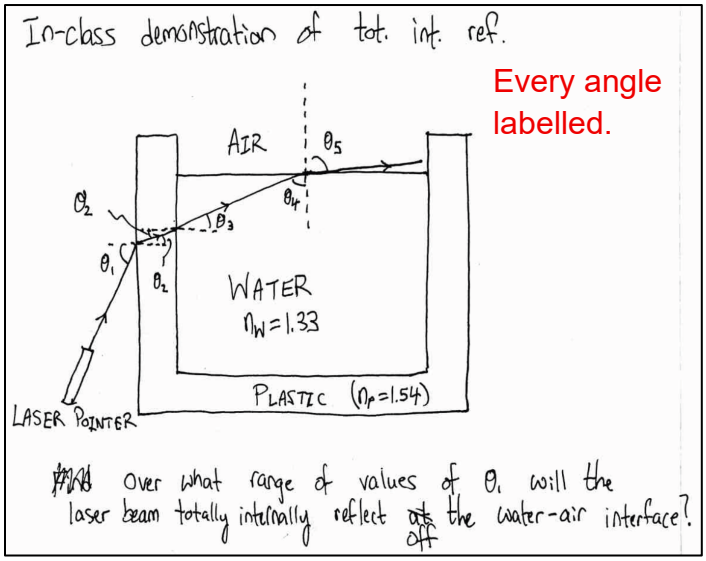
to me

Great hearing from you! I hope you have been enjoying TAing 101B and making students excited about EM. Let me get in touch with my student and coordinate this. The earliest we can do will be on Wednesday. Would that work for you? Have a nice weekend.

Exhibit 3: Demonstration of total internal reflection

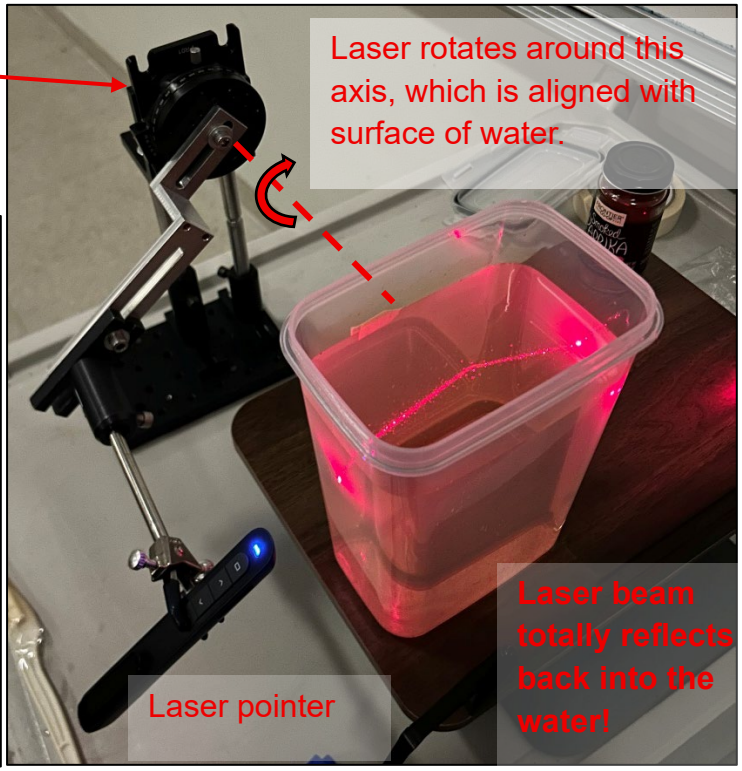
I built an experimental setup to excite students about optics. Experiment demonstrates that, at and beyond a certain angle of incidence, a wave will be totally reflected from the interface between two media (in this case, water and air). This was built using lab optical equipment, my red laser pointer, a bucket of water, and some smoked paprika to "scatter" the laser beam so it'd be visible to the eye. A schematic of the problem from my discussion notes is shown.

Problem setup in discussion notes.



Every angle labelled.

Contraption I built to hold the laser.

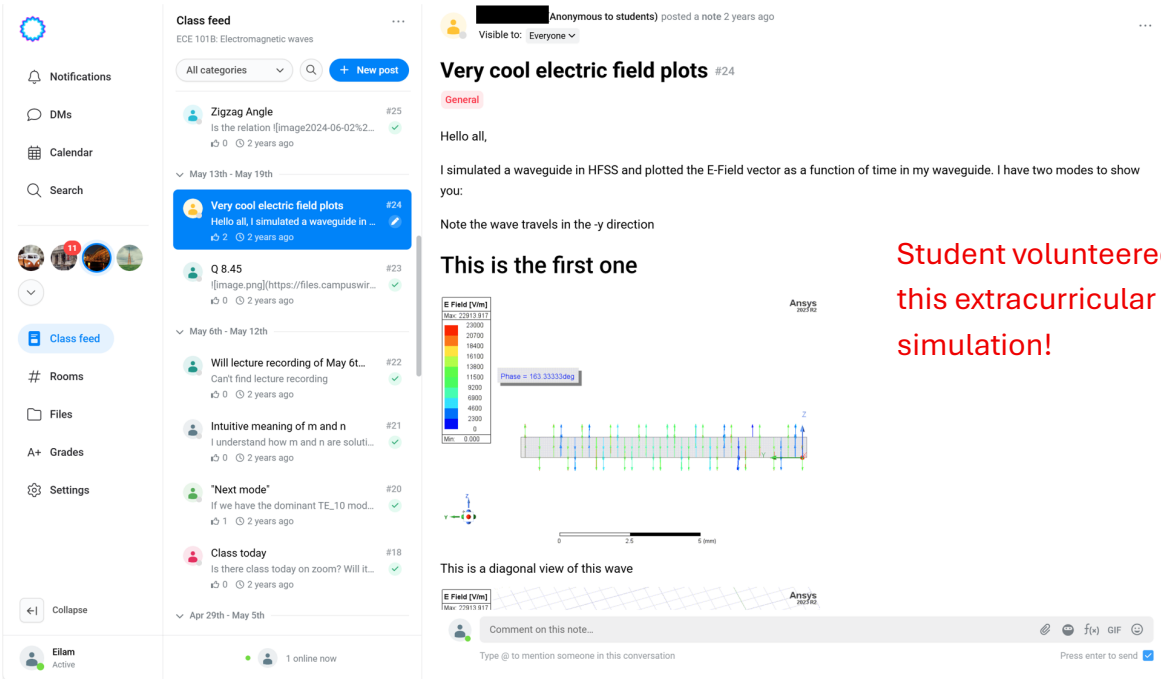


ARTIFACT 5: online engagement

Exhibit 1: Campuswire page, 101B S24

This is a screenshot of the class Campuswire page I set up and monitored, highlighting a student post sharing a relevant simulation they ran (not as part of any assignment!) with the class.

Active feed!

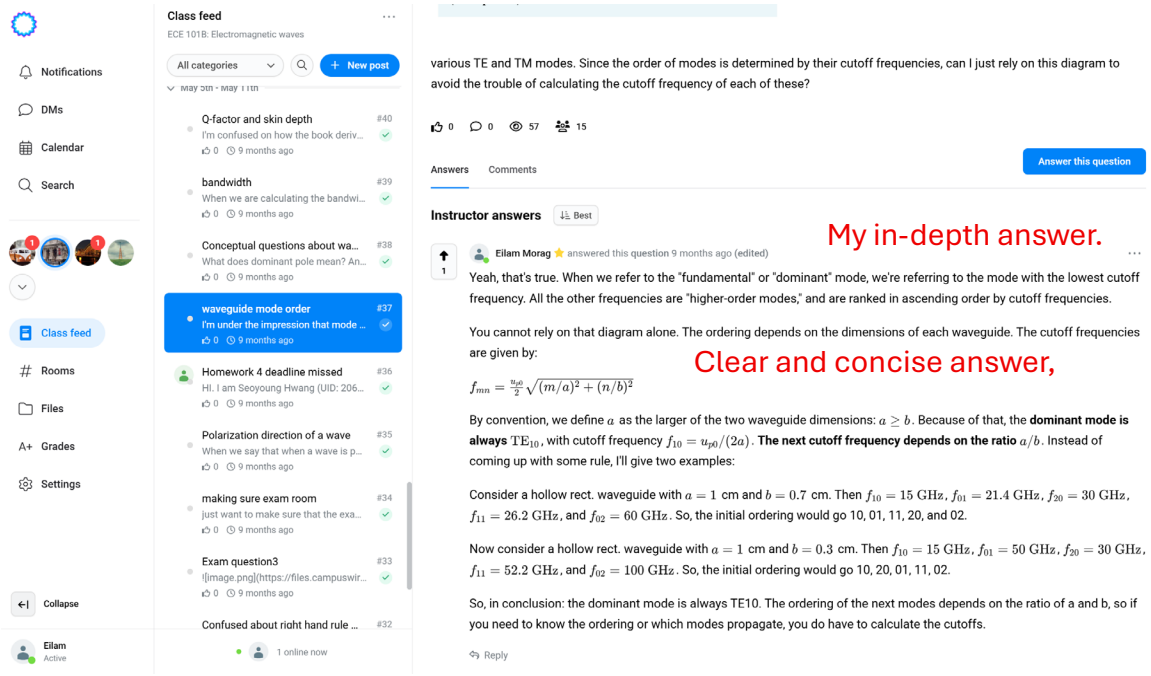


Student volunteered this extracurricular simulation!

Exhibit 2: Campuswire page, 101B S25

This is a screenshot of the Campuswire page I set up and monitored for the Spring 2025 offering of 101B. You can see a question I answered in depth.

Very active! 74 total posts, roughly one a day on average



My in-depth answer.

Clear and concise answer,

Prompting student to consider other cases

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name: Parsa Hamidi

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I had the pleasure of being in two classes where Eilam served as the TA: Physics for Electrical Engineers (ECE 2) and Electromagnetic Waves (ECE 101B). I would frequently attend his discussions and office hours for both classes, which I found very helpful and enjoyable.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

My first class with Eilam was ECE 2, which at the time was perhaps the most challenging college class that I had taken. The readings and lecture material were very dense and difficult to work through, leading me and many of my classmates to Eilam's discussion sessions and office hours nearly every week. It was clear that Eilam cared about students' learning effectively, as he would draw detailed diagrams for us, re-derive equations from the lecture, and explain the lecture material intuitively, all of which inspired me to work to understand the content in the same deep way that he did. At all of his sessions, it was clear that Eilam prioritized his position as a TA and genuinely wanted to be there.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Eilam's teaching style of building the students' intuition about the lecture material and homework problems greatly helped me in my most recent electromagnetics class with

him, ECE 101B. In our weekly discussions, he would bring in different structures such as antennas and waveguides from his research lab, and pass them around for the students to see. Being able to hold a tangible version of what we were studying in class really helped me to visualize the complicated three dimensional differential equations that we were solving, and made me even more interested in the material.

This understanding directly transitioned to giving me an advantage at my last summer internship, where I was working in a microwave laboratory with those very same components.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Within the two classes I've had with him, I've seen Eilam truly go above and beyond in his responsibilities as a teaching assistant. He prioritizes student learning in a positive and encouraging environment, and always had a smile on his face during our sessions. I owe a great deal of my technical interests and academic successes at UCLA to Eilam's outstanding efforts, and I could not recommend him more for this award.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant
Letter of Recommendation for Eilam Morag

Name
Heran Yang

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)
Eilam was my TA for two classes: ECE 2H Physics for Electrical Engineers with Professor Williams and ECE 101B Electromagnetic Waves with Professor Jarrahi. He is also currently the graduate student mentor for my ECE 181DA/DB Honors Thesis project.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)
Eilam's enthusiasm for instructing others inspired me to attend his discussion sections, and it also influenced me to attend discussion for other classes more often. Before taking ECE 2H, I rarely attended discussion sections since they often lacked enough review content for the full fifty minutes. However, I found Eilam's discussions for ECE 2H extremely valuable due to his review of lecture content in a more digestible format, as well as his increased engagement with students compared to lecture by asking questions to the class. Discussion sections complemented lecture, which motivated me to attend discussion each week to ensure that I had a solid grasp on the course content. Additionally, Eilam made an effort to make discussion sections lively and welcoming. He occasionally cracks jokes in class and makes an effort to learn every student's name, which helps make attending discussion enjoyable. I noticed that a majority of students consistently attended discussion throughout the entire quarter for both ECE 2H and ECE 101B, which I believe is a testament to Eilam's effective teaching methods and warm attitude.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)
One aspect of Eilam's discussion sections that I found beneficial was his thoughtfulness in selecting practice problems to address the shortcomings of lecture and homework. The problems that he worked through in discussion were either original or carefully selected to bridge the gap between the basic problems presented in lecture and the advanced problems from homeworks and exams. For example, we were taught how to solve for the wavefunctions in a 1-dimensional square well in ECE 2H lecture, and we were asked to do the same for a 3-dimensional square well for homework. Eilam worked through the same problem for a 2-dimensional square well, which taught us how we could generalize to higher dimensions without spoiling the solution of the homework problem.

Another aspect of Eilam's discussion sections that was really helpful was his ability to speak about real-world examples to help clarify theoretical concepts. Many topics covered in ECE 101B are very abstract, and his experience and knowledge from working in a photonics lab help emphasize the significance of scientific principles. Eilam recently showed me a physical apparatus he constructed to visualize total internal reflection for his current discussion section, which impressed me as going above and beyond.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

I believe that Eilam is an outstanding candidate for this award because he genuinely cares about the success of his students. He always prepares thoroughly before discussion sections to ensure that there is a clear lesson plan and example problems that emphasize understanding of the material. His preparation also leads him to be able to answer students' questions with insightful responses. I greatly appreciated his dedication to teaching, and it was the deciding factor when I selected my Honors Thesis project, since I chose the project where Eilam would serve as my mentor.

Professor Mona Jarrahi
Phone: (310) 206 1371
Fax: (310) 825 8282
Email: mjarrahi@ucla.edu

DEPARTMENT OF ELECTRICAL ENGINEERING
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095

02/05/2026

To whom it may concern,

It is with great pleasure that I nominate an outstanding teaching assistant, Eilam Morag, for this year's Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. Eilam joined UCLA as an M.S. student in Fall 2018 and has since continued his Ph.D. studies under the supervision of Prof. Benjamin Williams.

Eilam and I have worked together on six courses. He has served as my teaching assistant for five offerings of ECE 101B (including this quarter) and as my teaching assistant consultant (TAC) for ECE M495. In addition, he has been a TA for ECE 2 with Prof. Marko Sokolich twice and for ECE 2H with Prof. Benjamin Williams once. His responsibilities in ECE 101B include holding two to three discussion sections and two office hours per week; setting up and maintaining the class BruinLearn pages; uploading homework assignments and coordinating with the grader; and writing, proctoring, and grading the midterm and final exams. He has also delivered the midterm review lecture on two occasions. As a TAC for ECE M495, Eilam designed and coordinated nearly every aspect of the course, including its structure, class activities, and homework assignments, and provided primary feedback during microteaching practice sessions. His sincerity, dedication, and passion for teaching have led me to nominate him for this well-deserved award.

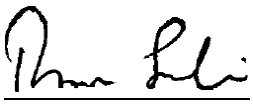
Eilam truly stands out among the teaching assistants I have worked with, as reflected in the consistently positive experiences students have had working with him. He always encourages students to participate and ask questions. During our first two quarters working together, he attended every lecture and answered questions during the mid-class break. He set up and actively monitored a Campuswire page and encouraged students to reach out by email if they were struggling. He also tutored students who had fallen behind in one-on-one settings. His discussion sections were taught primarily at the blackboard, where he reviewed the week's material and worked through original practice problems modeled on the homework assignments.

Eilam frequently went beyond standard expectations to help students grasp challenging concepts. He prepared supplemental materials to break down difficult topics: for example, when students were learning about waveguides, he created animations illustrating the time evolution of electromagnetic fields; when covering wave reflections, he developed animations of standing waves. To further bring theory to life, he incorporated physical demonstrations into his teaching. During discussions on rectangular metal

waveguides, he brought in actual waveguides from his lab and had students compute relevant parameters based on their dimensions. During the antenna unit, he coordinated with Prof. Rahmat-Samii to obtain permission to bring research antennas from his lab for demonstration.

In summary, Eilam has gone far beyond typical TA responsibilities in service of our students. His passion for teaching, dedication to his courses, and strong sense of integrity make him a tremendous asset to our department. I strongly recommend him for this year's Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants and wish him every success in his future endeavors.

Sincerely,



Mona Jarrahi
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